Business schools have a seminal role to play in building business leaders of tomorrow, one that will be led by technology

By Kaushik Deka

Management education in India has been on a transformative trajectory, evolving from a niche offering to being a critical component of the country's higher education landscape. With over 3,200 institutions and hundreds of thousands of students enrolling each year, management courses have become a cornerstone for aspiring business leaders. In contrast to global trends, where applications to MBA programmes have dropped by over 8 per cent in recent years, India has witnessed a surge. More than 330,000 candidates registered for the Common Admission Test (CAT) in 2023, a 30 per cent rise from the previous year. Reflecting this increased interest, the intake at the top 100 business schools expanded by 15 per cent in 2023-24.

As India grows into its role as a rising economic giant, the need for adept managers capable of navigating the complexities of a globalised business environment has never been greater. According to the online professional network LinkedIn, the share of senior leaders hired with an MBA has grown by 25 per cent globally since 2010. That is something the India Skills Report 2024 also bears out: MBA graduates enjoy an employability rate of 71.2 per cent, significantly outpacing other disciplines. This underscores the enduring value of management education in shaping the future of work.

However, the rapid proliferation of management institutes in India has come with significant challenges, particularly in maintaining consistent quality, adequate infrastructure and alignment with the ever-evolving demands of industry. In this shifting landscape, the India Today Group MDRA Best Business Schools Survey has emerged as a crucial compass to guide students, educators and recruiters. By evaluating institutions on key parameters such as academic rigour, faculty expertise, industry engagement and technological innovation, the annual survey acts as a reliable framework to make informed choices in a competitive educational market.

Like the editions before it, the India Today Group MDRA Best Business Schools Survey this year, too, should serve as the most credible barometer of management education in India. With participation from 275 management institutes, including the prestigious Indian Institutes of Management (IIMs), this survey provides an insightful snapshot of the evolving trends in business education. Though cementing its position, IIM-Calcutta retains the top spot among B-Schools for the fourth consecutive year.

TOP 10 B-SCHOOLS OF INDIA

RANK (2024)	RANK (2023)	NAME OF THE INSTITUTE	CITY	CATEGORY
1	1	INDIAN INSTITUTE OF MANAGEMENT-CALCUTTA	Kolkata	Government
2	4	INDIAN INSTITUTE OF MANAGEMENT-LUCKNOW	Lucknow	Government
3	5	S.P. JAIN INSTITUTE OF MANAGEMENT AND RESEARCH	Mumbai	Private
4	DNP	INDIAN INSTITUTE OF MANAGEMENT- KOZHIKODE	Kozhikode	Government
5	6	INDIAN INSTITUTE OF MANAGEMENT-INDORE	Indore	Government
6	7	MANAGEMENT DEVELOPMENT INSTITUTE- GURGAON	Gurugram	Private
7	9	INDIAN INSTITUTE OF FOREIGN TRADE	New Delhi	Government
8	10	SVKM'S NMIMS SCHOOL OF BUSINESS MANAGEMENT	Mumbai	Private
9	12	INDIAN INSTITUTE OF MANAGEMENT-SHILLONG	Shillong	Government
10	11	INTERNATIONAL MANAGEMENT INSTITUTE	New Delhi	Private

Guiding Principle

However, the significance of this survey extends beyond ranking institutions. Its assessment of key areas like curriculum, faculty quality, industry linkages and infrastructure encourages institutions to do better. With the cost of management education rising and technology causing disruption in the job market, students need to know which institutes are best preparing them for the jobs of the future.

For, the quality of management education remains uneven across institutions, with many B-schools beset by inadequate faculty and infrastructure, resulting in a mismatch between academic training and industry requirement. This year's survey captures the widening gap between the top-tier

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